

The Outbound Reality Check

The real end-to-end conversion numbers, how to size the machine backwards from a revenue goal, and how to find the one layer quietly killing your outbound.

Most outbound decks lie to you with two numbers: open rate and a 25% close rate. Neither survives contact with reality. This is the honest version. The math we actually run, and the checklist we use to find where a funnel leaks. Built from real closed:in campaigns, nothing inflated.

Who this is for

Founders and GTM leads who are running cold outbound, or about to, and have no honest benchmark to hold it against.

Everything below assumes the standard closed:in setup so the numbers are comparable:

- **7,000 prospects per month** as the reference volume.
- **3-step sequence** (one email plus two follow-ups), plain text.
- **Blended targeting.** Not the best-case niche, not spray. A real mix.

If your setup differs, scale the numbers. The ratios hold.

The honest funnel (the numbers competitors hide)

Three scenarios, so you can see the floor and the ceiling instead of a single hopeful number. Worked on 7,000 prospects per month.

Stage	Conservative	Mid	Aggressive
Prospects / month	7,000	7,000	7,000
Reply rate	2.5%	3%	3.5%
Replies	175	210	245
Positive (33% of replies)	58	69	81
Booked (50 / 60 / 70% of positive)	29	42	57
Held (75 / 75 / 80% show)	22	31	45
SQO (95% of held)	21	30	43
Closed-won (10 / 15 / 20% close)	2	4 to 5	8 to 9

Read that bottom row again. At 7,000 prospects a month, a healthy cold engine closes 2 to 9 new clients. Pin your plan on the mid column, not the aggressive one.

One rule that separates honest from hopeful: reply rate falls as targeting broadens.

- Curated, signal-driven plays (replacing a hire, reacting to a live trigger): **5 to 7%**.
- Broad coverage: **1.5 to 2%**.
- A real blend at 7,000 per month: **2.5 to 3.5%**.

Anyone quoting you one flat reply rate across every audience has not run enough campaigns.

Reverse the math: from a goal to the infrastructure

“Do more outbound” is not a plan. Start from the only number that matters and run it backwards. Mid rates, target of **2 new clients per month**:

- 2 clients ÷ 15% close = **~14 SQO**
- ÷ 95% SQO rate = **~15 held meetings**
- ÷ 75% show = **~20 booked meetings**
- ÷ 60% book = **~32 positive replies**
- ÷ 33% positive = **~95 replies**
- ÷ 3% reply = **~3,200 prospects per month**

Now that is an infrastructure spec, not a vibe. At a 3-step sequence, ~3,200 prospects per month means roughly **10 sending domains and 20 inboxes**.

The formula behind it: 2 inboxes per domain, 25 sends per inbox per day, 21 working days, 3-step sequence.

Domains	Inboxes	Sends / day	Prospects / month
10	20	500	3,500
20	40	1,000	7,000
40	80	2,000	14,000

Scaling is linear. Double the domains, double the volume. This is also how you sanity-check a founder's target: if the numbers say you need 60 domains to hit the goal, the goal or the offer needs work, not the send button.

The machine (scrape, enrich, send)

The email gets all the attention. The list quietly decides whether the email even matters. Treat the list as a pipeline, not a purchase.

Scrape - Pull from several sources, never one bought CSV. - Lead with a signal in the prospect's world, not with yourself.

Enrich - Merge and dedupe across sources. - Waterfall to a verified email across multiple providers (a good waterfall hits ~95%). - Verify again, kill bounces before they touch a domain. - Tag by persona so copy can segment.

Send - Plain text, 3-step. A human reads every send before it goes out. - Park no-fit and no-email records, recycle them on the next refresh. Nothing gets thrown away, so the list compounds. - Outcomes land in the CRM and feed straight back into the list stage: re-enrich, re-segment, reach again with a better reason.

The 5-layer diagnostic: which layer is broken

Outbound fails as a symptom. Fix the layer, not the symptom. This is the read we run on our own funnel every month.

Symptom	Broken layer	The fix
No replies at all	List or infra	Off-ICP, unverified, or a bought CSV. Or deliverability. Rebuild the list as a pipeline, check the sending health.
Replies, but all negative or “not now”	Offer or trigger	The offer gives no reason to talk this week. Make it new-money, de-risked, done-for-you, and lead with a signal in their world.
Positive replies, few booked	The meeting-ask and follow-up speed	Call positives fast and structured. In trust-heavy markets, raw reply volume overstates how ready buyers actually are.
Dead after month one	The CRM loop	Outcomes are not feeding back into the list. A funnel that never loops decays. Close the loop.
Warmest signal ignored	Routing	Website visitors and content engagers go to a human, not into a sequence.

The rules nobody tells you

- **Open rate is not in this document and never will be.** Apple Mail broke it years ago. Anyone still reporting it is selling you a number they cannot trust.
- **Close rate is not 25%.** Model 10 to 20%. Mid is 15%. If a founder claims higher, believe it after you have measured it, not before.
- **Reply rate falls as targeting broadens.** 5 to 7% curated, 1.5 to 2% broad, 2.5 to 3.5% blended.
- **One value asset per follow-up.** Never a stack. Overload kills the reply.
- **Nothing gets thrown away.** The list compounds every refresh.

- **A human reads every send before it goes.**
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Proof it is not theory

- **A sustainability client, saturated market:** 142 opportunities in 13 weeks. Niche-first beats volume-first when the market is crowded.
 - **A creator agency with an audience that sits in no database:** 33 opportunities, 8.47% reply rate, 6,800 emails, 0 databases used. The list was built from the Instagram follow-graph. Proof that the list, not the copy, is usually the constraint.
 - **An accountancy firm in a trust-heavy market:** ~48 opportunities in ~6 weeks, 4 meetings booked, 1 new client. The lesson: reply volume overstated readiness, so that market is won on the follow-up layer, not on raw volume.
 - **A crypto project with no list to buy:** 17,213 domains screened down to 2,230 confirmed operators and 2,253 verified emails. Predicted 70 to 80% email findability before sending a single message, hit 72%. Size it before you spend.
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The one thing to apply

The email gets all the attention. The list quietly decides whether the email even matters. Before you rewrite a subject line, find the layer that is actually broken: list, offer, copy, infra, or the loop. Fix that one first.

Want a second read on where yours is leaking? I run this exact diagnostic on our own funnel every month. Give me 30 minutes and your numbers, we walk your ICP together, and you leave knowing the single layer to fix first. Curious what we would find: closedin.neetocal.com/discovery-call-with-max-munstermann

Max Münstermann closed:in